



CHINESE STUDIES GLOBAL WEBINAR - FALL 2026

CENTER FOR CHINESE STUDIES, UNIVERSITY OF HAWAII AT MĀNOA

FREE
to public

An established bilingual international online forum for dialogue, discovery, and connection in Chinese Studies



SEPT. 23

WEDNESDAY

12:00 PM -1:30 PM HST



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INDIVIDUAL RESEARCH PRESENTATION

A Nation That Shows Up?

Giving, Volunteering and Civic Life in Contemporary China

Does an authoritarian state crowd out civil society? Or is civic energy in China simply a Western civil society waiting to bloom?

Drawing on five waves of the Civic Participation in China Survey (2018–2026), this presentation describes a civic culture that is collaborative rather than adversarial, intrinsically motivated rather than incentive-driven, and increasingly mediated by digital platforms rather than legacy institutions. By 2026, roughly three in four adults report donating to a charitable cause and nearly two thirds report volunteering—rates rivaling those of wealthy democracies, despite China's comparatively young and regulated nonprofit sector. That same year marks a measurable turning point: independent foundations overtook state-linked ones as the leading recipients of individual donations for the first time in the survey's history. Centering ordinary citizens' behavior and beliefs rather than policy documents or organizational registries, the talk offers a bottom-up complement to top-down accounts of civil society governance. It also invites comparison with Hawai'i's own layered histories of diasporic and community-based giving.



SPEAKER

REZA HASMATH

Reza Hasmath (Ph.D., Cambridge) is a Full Professor in Political Science at the University of Alberta. He has previously held faculty positions in management, sociology and political science at the Universities of Toronto, Melbourne and Oxford. His award winning research looks at evolving state-society relationships in authoritarian contexts, with an emphasis on China. He currently serves as the Executive Director of ARNOVA, and the Editor-in-Chief of the Journal of Civil Society.



DISCUSSANT

QIAN WEI

Qian Wei is an Assistant Professor of Sociology at Wilfrid Laurier University. Before joining Laurier, she worked as a Postdoctoral Researcher at Stanford University (2021–2023) and the University of British Columbia (2019–2021). She received her Ph.D. in Sociology from Memorial University in 2019. Her research interests focus on civil society, civic participation, nonprofit organizations, democracy and (de)globalization.



MODERATOR

LE LIN

Le Lin (Ph.D., Sociology, University of Chicago) is Associate Professor of Sociology at the University of Hawaii at Manoa. His research centers on education, organizations, economic sociology, transnational sociology and Chinese society.



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